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SECURITY BRIEF

CYBERSECURITY, SOVEREIGNTY AND DIGITAL TRUST

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In the 21st century, governments no longer merely guard frontiers of land and sea; they also compete over control of the digital realm. For countries globally, the imperative to build resilient cybersecurity, assert digital sovereignty, and foster digital trust is particularly acute. These three pillars are deeply interwoven: without sovereignty, there is little control; without trust, adoption of digital services falters; without strong cybersecurity, neither sovereignty nor trust can endure.

Cybersecurity in the Global South: Rising threats, fragile defences

Cyber threats do not wait for development; they exploit it. Globally, weaker infrastructure, limited human capacity, and fragmented regulatory regimes exacerbate risk.

Take the case of mobile money and fintech platforms in Africa. Nations such as Ghana, Kenya, and Nigeria have adopted robust cybersecurity policies on paper, but enforcement and sectoral coordination are weak, undermining user confidence in digital financial systems.

Similarly, in Latin America, municipalities have fallen prey to ransomware attacks that cripple urban services, a reminder that weak local governance can become a national vulnerability.

Thus, cybersecurity must be viewed not as a technical issue, but as a system-of-systems issue, linking governance, human capital, infrastructure, and international cooperation.

Digital sovereignty:

What it means, and why it matters

Digital sovereignty (also called cyber-sovereignty, data sovereignty, technological sovereignty) refers to a country's ability to exercise authority and control over its digital infrastructure, data, and the rules governing them.

In Africa, digital sovereignty is often conflated with data localisation, requiring that data generated within a country be stored and processed domestically. But critics argue that localisation is not, by itself, sovereignty, especially when infrastructure and management are controlled by foreign corporations.

For example, several African countries are investing in national data centres (Benin, Senegal, Togo) as part of their sovereignty agenda, but face challenges of power reliability, cooling, connectivity, and affordability.

In South Africa, scholars have proposed models of digital sovereignty that encompass not only data location but a domestic stack, meaning ownership of hardware, middleware, cloud platforms, and digital public infrastructure.

Elsewhere, Latin American countries such as Brazil and Mexico are debating similar questions: How much control to assert without stifling innovation or discouraging foreign investment.

Digital trust:

The "glue" that holds the system together

Digital trust is the citizen's belief that online systems, government platforms, and private services operate reliably, safely, transparently, and accountably. Without trust, adoption stalls.

In Africa, mistrust of government systems is a serious obstacle. Many citizens are wary of handing over personal data to state agencies known for weak accountability.

In Brazil, the 2018 General Data Protection Law (LGPD) has become a key building block in restoring trust by clarifying consent, delineating processing rights, and mandating penalties.

In India, the Aadhaar system (a biometric ID) has sparked frequent debates. While it enables scale and efficiency, concerns over data leaks, misuse, and a lack of redress have eroded citizen confidence.

In countries where mobile money is widely used (e.g., Kenya's M-Pesa or Ghana's mobile wallets), robust security practices and visible safeguards have helped establish trust, but breaches and fraud still quickly erode public perception.

Interplay and tensions:

Sovereignty, security and trust

These three pillars, namely, cybersecurity, sovereignty, and trust, do not always align. Many countries walk a fine line, asserting control while preserving openness and innovation.

A promising path lies in regional coordination. In Africa, for instance, a harmonised approach to data centres, cyber norms, and procurement can improve bargaining power and reduce duplication.

Data embassies are another intriguing concept. Instead of building a data centre in every country, a trusted partner state can host critical national data under treaty-based sovereignty arrangements.